

BEST Management Advice

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“BE A CULTURAL CHAMELEON WITHOUT LOSING CORE VALUES”

Q As a successful woman leader, what challenges have you faced, and how did you overcome them?

Honestly, it's rarely one large “glass ceiling” moment; it's more like twelve small things that happen in any given week when you are a woman leader. You even hear those quiet murmurs suggesting you might not be “comfortable with numbers”—which is a bit ironic when you were a math major and went to a top business school.

Overcoming that is a constant balancing act.

Q You have worked across functions, whereas others who became CEOs—such as Leena Nair—focused on a single function. What is your advice for ambitious next-generation leaders?

Look, there is immense value in single-function expertise. When someone attains deep mastery



of a specific domain, it creates a very solid, undeniable “expert” brand.

My choices have more to do with my personality—I am deeply curious—that has been my super power. I want to understand each piece of the puzzle enough to help drive how to bring them together. My moves through strategy, sales, and marketing were about satisfying that need to see how a high-level strategy actually hits the ground in a sales territory. To the next generation: if you feel that same pull, follow it. Functional silos are

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Q As someone who has worked with multiple companies across many countries, what is your advice for executives who seek diverse experiences?

Diverse experience is the ultimate “metabolic” boost for a career. Working across geographies teaches you that while business fundamentals are universal, context is everything. You cannot manage a team in Shanghai the same way you do in Mumbai or Cupertino.

My advice for executives is twofold. First, “Seek the Friction”: Go where you will need to find patterns in chaos or signals in noise—where growth is messy and markets are emerging and need defining. That's where you develop real leadership muscle. Second is contextual leadership. You must be a “cultural chameleon” without losing your core values. Your leadership intent stays the same, but your delivery must adapt. In some contexts, leadership is about consensus and influence; in others, it's about decisive, top-down clarity. If you can't pivot your style, you can't scale globally. **BT**

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